



A CAN-DO MANIFESTO

Every citizen's quest should be to create a better India, whether it is saving the environment, fighting for the rights of the people, making sure even the most underprivileged don't sleep on an empty stomach or enabling the state to be in touch with the needs of its citizens. For it is in its citizens that a country's future lies. And in my experience, I have learnt the common man can make a difference by voicing his opinions about how he thinks India should be.

I remember, whether it was agitation for land displacement or the water fight, we always had the youth from all over India visiting us. It could have been curiosity or a genuine desire to help, but they always wanted to make a difference. That's why, I think, it is imperative to have a plan for them. These young people are the real spirit behind development but to actively participate, they have to see the real India beyond the glossy dreams of glittering cities. Those under the age of 30 comprise 60 per cent of the population, which is reason enough for a new youth movement.

Every third illiterate in the world lives in India and 296 million Indians are still illiterate. We have to ensure education reaches the masses and facilitates a responsible people's movement to aid the underprivileged. But this should be education with a difference, not a western-inspired model, but a system tailored to meet the specific needs of the people. Community help for these plans is a great way. I realised in the 12

schools we have in the Narmada valley, where the teachers are all from tribal areas, that children learn better when they feel they have something in common with teachers.

Much of my endeavour has been to create awareness about the injustice to the environment. It is still not a priority. There should be people-driven efforts that will help in envisioning a culture that harnesses resources effectively. For instance, we must stop groundwater from becoming an exploited commodity. Almost 25 lakh litre of water goes to corporate bodies to be bottled, at cheap costs—Rs 5 to 10 per litre. Not only are people being deprived of basic commodities but the water tables clearly show its ill-effects.

Being a woman and having worked extensively with many, it is evident that the stature given to them is very poor. They should be given stronger roles in society and greater opportunities, especially, in panchayati raj, to free them from the bondage of patriarchal protection. They account for 48 per cent of the population and it's time their efforts were recognised.

Politics, being another push point, can be a double-edged weapon—to be used for growth or to cause further damage to democracy. People should be encouraged to enter the political arena to give back what they take from

the country. Politicians and voters should look beyond party lines. Everyone should dwell in universality and secularism rather than segregation. Gram sabhas and lok manches are effective in connecting the needy, privileged youth and can-doers who don't believe in the could-have-been phenomenon.

In the same way, shramdaan has been a major factor in renewing the spirit of India. We must keep such a culture going. Baba Amte, who devoted his life to serving society, always supported my causes,

even when they seemed impossible. It was in him perhaps that I saw the true concept of shramdaan and learnt so much. In the end to attain a society where there is equity, we need a nation where there is no landlessness. Land reforms are then the key to all

transformation, for having a piece of land that one can call one's own is the greatest sense of security. I believe that we must keep the Mahatma-advocated swadeshi alive, from self-education to self-healing to self-medication.

India has a long history of people who have dedicated their lives to the betterment of society. The spirit of India can be kept alive by giving a little of ourselves to make a lot of someone else's life.

The author is a social activist



SHUTS THE BIGGEST MOUTHS.



THE BIG MINT.